Industry Starter Pack

Construction & Trades Edition

A ZANDER SYSTEMS PUBLICATION

Operating Simply Methodology

$149

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01

Estimating & Bidding

Win profitable projects

Industry Starter Pack: Construction

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02

Project Management

On time, on budget

By Zander Systems | Operating Simply Methodology

03

Crew Scheduling

Right people, right place

1. The Construction Business Operating System
2. Estimating and Bidding Templates
3. Project Management Framework
4. Job Costing and Financial Tracking
5. Safety and Compliance Checklists
6. Subcontractor Management
7. Client Communication Templates
8. Growth and Scaling Playbook

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04

Safety & Compliance

Protect your team

The 5 Pillars of a Construction Business

Every successful contractor operates on these pillars:

```
                    REVENUE
                       ▲
                       |
     ┌─────────────────┼─────────────────┐
     |                 |                 |
ESTIMATING ──────► PROJECT MGMT ◄────── OPERATIONS
     |                 |                 |
     └─────────────────┼─────────────────┘
                       |
                       ▼
                    FINANCE
```

Estimating: Win profitable work, not just any work **Project Management:** Deliver on time, on budget **Operations:** Build efficiently with skilled teams **Finance:** Know your numbers, protect your margins **Revenue:** Grow sustainably with the right clients

Know Your Numbers: Key Metrics

```
CONSTRUCTION COMPANY DASHBOARD
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SALES METRICS
  Bids Submitted This Month          _____
  Win Rate (Jobs Won / Bids)         _____%
  Average Job Size                   $_____
  Pipeline Value                     $_____

PROJECT METRICS
  Active Jobs                        _____
  Jobs on Schedule                   _____ (____%)
  Jobs on Budget                     _____ (____%)
  Change Order Rate                  _____%

FINANCIAL METRICS
  Gross Margin (Actual)              _____%
  Gross Margin (Target)              _____%
  Overhead Rate                      _____%
  Break-Even Revenue (Monthly)       $_____
```

```
OPERATIONAL METRICS
  Labor Utilization                    _____%
  Callbacks / Warranty Claims          _____
  Safety Incidents                     _____
  Subcontractor On-Time Rate           _____%
```

The Construction Revenue Formula

```
Revenue = (Bid Volume × Win Rate × Avg Job Size)

Example:
  20 bids/month × 25% win rate × $50,000 avg = $250,000/month

To grow revenue, improve:
1. Bid Volume → Better marketing, more relationships
2. Win Rate → Better estimating, right-sizing bids
3. Average Job Size → Move upmarket, bundles
```

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Subcontractor Management

Build your network

The Estimate Checklist

Before submitting any bid:

Checklist

- [ ] Site visit completed
- [ ] Plans and specs reviewed
- [ ] Scope clearly defined
- [ ] Timeline requirements understood
- [ ] Decision maker identified
- [ ] Materials takeoff complete
- [ ] Labor hours calculated
- [ ] Equipment needs identified
- [ ] Subcontractor quotes received (min. 2 per trade)
- [ ] Permits and fees included
- [ ] Contingency added
- [ ] Direct costs verified
- [ ] Overhead applied correctly
- [ ] Profit margin acceptable
- [ ] Compared to similar past jobs
- [ ] No math errors

- [ ] Proposal formatted professionally
- [ ] Terms and conditions included
- [ ] Insurance certificates ready
- [ ] References available
- [ ] Follow-up date scheduled

Cost Estimation Template

```
DETAILED ESTIMATE WORKSHEET
____________________________________________________

Job Name: _______________
Customer: _______________
Estimator: _______________
Date: _______________

DIRECT COSTS
____________________________________________________

Materials:
  Item              Qty     Unit     Cost      Total
  _____________     ____    ____     $____     $_____
  _____________     ____    ____     $____     $_____
  _____________     ____    ____     $____     $_____
  Tax (_____%)                                 $_____
  ___________________________________________________
  Materials Subtotal                           $_____

Labor:
  Trade             Hours   Rate     Cost      Total
  _____________     ____    $____             $_____
  _____________     ____    $____             $_____
  Burden (_____%)                              $_____
  ___________________________________________________
  Labor Subtotal                               $_____

Equipment:
  Item              Days    Rate     Cost      Total
  _____________     ____    $____             $_____
  _____________     ____    $____             $_____
  ___________________________________________________
  Equipment Subtotal                           $_____

Subcontractors:
```

```
  Trade              Scope   Quote              Total
  _____________      ____    $_____            $_____
  _____________      ____    $_____            $_____
  ____________________________________________________
  Subcontractor Subtotal                        $_____

Other Direct Costs:
  Permits                                       $_____
  Dumpster/Waste                                $_____
  Temporary Utilities                           $_____
  _____________                                 $_____
  ____________________________________________________
  Other Direct Subtotal                         $_____

____________________________________________________
TOTAL DIRECT COSTS                              $_____

INDIRECT COSTS
____________________________________________________
  Overhead (_____%)                             $_____
  Contingency (_____%)                          $_____
  ____________________________________________________
  Total Indirect                                $_____

____________________________________________________
SUBTOTAL                                        $_____
Profit Margin (_____%)                          $_____
____________________________________________________
BID PRICE                                       $_____
```

The Proposal Template

```
[COMPANY LOGO]

PROPOSAL

Prepared for: [Client Name]
Project: [Project Name]
Date: [Date]
Valid until: [Date + 30 days]

____________________________________________________


Dear [Client Name],

Thank you for the opportunity to provide this proposal
for [brief project description].

SCOPE OF WORK
```

```
We will provide the following:
• [Detailed scope item 1]
• [Detailed scope item 2]
• [Detailed scope item 3]

EXCLUSIONS

The following are NOT included:
• [Exclusion 1]
• [Exclusion 2]

INVESTMENT

Total Project Price: $[Amount]

Payment Terms:
• [Deposit %] upon contract signing
• [Progress payments schedule]
• [Final payment terms]

TIMELINE

Estimated Start: [Date]
Estimated Completion: [Date]
Total Duration: [X] weeks

ABOUT US

[2-3 sentences about your company, years in business,
specialties, what makes you different]

WARRANTY

[Your warranty terms]

ACCEPTANCE

To proceed, please sign below and return with deposit.

_________________________________    ____________
Client Signature                      Date

_________________________________    ____________
Company Representative               Date

[Company Name | License # | Insurance Info]
[Address | Phone | Email | Website]
```

06

Client Communication

Updates that build trust

The Job Start Checklist

Before breaking ground:

Checklist

- [ ] Contract signed by all parties
- [ ] Deposit received and cleared
- [ ] Insurance certificates exchanged
- [ ] Permits pulled and posted
- [ ] Schedule created and shared
- [ ] Material orders placed
- [ ] Subcontractors scheduled
- [ ] Equipment reserved
- [ ] Crew assignments made
- [ ] Job folder created
- [ ] Plans on site
- [ ] Contact list distributed
- [ ] Safety plan reviewed with crew
- [ ] Pre-construction photos taken
- [ ] Site access confirmed
- [ ] Utilities located (call 811)

- [ ] Dumpster delivered
- [ ] Portable toilet placed
- [ ] Tool and material storage
- [ ] Kickoff meeting completed
- [ ] Communication preferences confirmed
- [ ] Weekly update schedule set
- [ ] Contact for emergencies identified

Daily Job Report

Complete every day on every active job:

Checklist

- [ ] None
- [ ] Weather delay: _____ hours
- [ ] Material delay: _____
- [ ] Subcontractor no-show: _____
- [ ] Other: _____
- [ ] Toolbox talk completed: Topic: _____
- [ ] Incidents: _____

The Weekly Project Review

Every Friday, review each active job:

Checklist

- [ ] None pending
- [ ] Submitted: $_____ Status: _____
- [ ] Approved this week: $_____

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Financial Controls

Job costing that works

The Job Cost Report

Track every dollar on every job:

```
JOB COST REPORT
____________________________________________________

Job #: ___________
Job Name: ______________
Report Date: ______________

SUMMARY
                     Budget      Actual      Variance
Revenue             $______     $______     $______
Direct Costs        $______     $______     $______
Gross Profit        $______     $______     $______
Gross Margin        _____%      _____%      ____%

COST DETAIL
Category            Budget      Actual      Variance    %
Labor              $______     $______     $______    ___
Materials          $______     $______     $______    ___
Equipment          $______     $______     $______    ___
Subcontractors     $______     $______     $______    ___
Other Direct       $______     $______     $______    ___
____________________________________________________
Total Direct       $______     $______     $______    ___

BILLING STATUS
  Contract:                    $______
  Change Orders:               $______
  Total Contract:              $______
  Billed to Date:              $______
  Collected:                   $______
  Remaining to Bill:           $______
  Retainage Held:              $______

COST VS. BILLING
  % Complete (Cost):           _____%
  % Billed:                    _____%
  Overbilled/(Underbilled):    $______

NOTES ON VARIANCES
____________________________________________________
____________________________________________________
```

Labor Productivity Tracking

Checklist

- [ ] On track
- [ ] Minor variance - monitor
- [ ] Significant variance - investigate
- [ ] Weather delays
- [ ] Material issues
- [ ] Scope creep
- [ ] Rework required
- [ ] Crew skill level
- [ ] Other: _____

Overhead Allocation

Know your true overhead rate:

```
ANNUAL OVERHEAD CALCULATION
____________________________________________________

FIXED OVERHEAD
  Office Rent                      $______
  Utilities                        $______
  Insurance (Liability, W/C)       $______
  Vehicle Expenses                 $______
  Office Staff Salaries            $______
  Professional Services            $______
  Software & Tools                 $______
  Marketing                        $______
  Other Fixed                      $______
____________________________________________________

Total Fixed Overhead               $______

OVERHEAD RATE CALCULATION
  Total Fixed Overhead             $______
```

```
  ÷ Direct Labor Costs          $______
  = Overhead Rate               _____%

Or:
  Total Fixed Overhead          $______
  ÷ Total Revenue               $______
  = Overhead as % of Revenue    _____%

BREAK-EVEN ANALYSIS
  Monthly Overhead              $______
  ÷ Gross Margin %              _____%
  = Monthly Break-Even Revenue  $______
```

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Growth Strategy

Scale without chaos

Daily Safety Checklist

Checklist

- [ ] Site access clear and safe
- [ ] Warning signs posted
- [ ] Housekeeping maintained
- [ ] Adequate lighting
- [ ] Emergency exits clear
- [ ] Guardrails in place where required
- [ ] Hole covers secure
- [ ] Ladders in good condition
- [ ] Harnesses available for heights >6 feet
- [ ] Scaffolding properly assembled
- [ ] Hard hats worn by all
- [ ] Safety glasses/goggles available
- [ ] Hearing protection where needed
- [ ] Appropriate footwear
- [ ] Gloves for material handling
- [ ] GFCI protection on all outlets

- [ ] Cords in good condition
- [ ] No exposed wiring
- [ ] Lockout/tagout procedures followed
- [ ] Guards in place on power tools
- [ ] Tools in good condition
- [ ] Operators trained on equipment
- [ ] Equipment inspected daily
- [ ] SDS sheets accessible
- [ ] Proper storage
- [ ] Spill kit available
- [ ] Ventilation adequate
- [ ] Extinguisher accessible
- [ ] Hot work permits if needed
- [ ] Flammables stored properly

OSHA Compliance Checklist

Checklist

- [ ] OSHA poster displayed
- [ ] Written safety program
- [ ] Hazard communication program
- [ ] Emergency action plan

- [ ] OSHA 300 log (if 10+ employees)
- [ ] Training records
- [ ] New hire safety orientation
- [ ] Hazard communication
- [ ] Fall protection
- [ ] Scaffold safety (if applicable)
- [ ] Confined space (if applicable)
- [ ] Respiratory protection (if applicable)
- [ ] Equipment-specific training
- [ ] Regular jobsite inspections
- [ ] Equipment inspections
- [ ] Documentation of corrections
- [ ] Incident reporting procedure
- [ ] First aid supplies on site
- [ ] Emergency contacts posted
- [ ] Workers' comp process documented

Pre-Task Safety Planning (JHA)

Checklist

- [ ] Hard hat ☐ Safety glasses ☐ Hearing protection
- [ ] Gloves ☐ Steel-toe boots ☐ Hi-vis vest

☐ Fall harness ☐ Respirator ☐ Other: _____

Subcontractor Qualification Checklist

Before awarding work:

Checklist

- [ ] W-9 on file
- [ ] Certificate of Insurance (verify coverage)
- [ ] State license # _____ (verified)
- [ ] References checked (min. 3)
- [ ] Approved - Add to bid list
- [ ] Conditional - Need: _____
- [ ] Rejected - Reason: _____

Subcontractor Agreement Essentials

Key terms to include:

Checklist

- [ ] Scope of work clearly defined
- [ ] Contract price and payment terms
- [ ] Schedule requirements and penalties
- [ ] Change order process

- [ ] Insurance requirements
- [ ] Indemnification clause
- [ ] Lien waiver requirements
- [ ] Safety compliance requirements
- [ ] Quality standards
- [ ] Cleanup responsibilities
- [ ] Warranty terms
- [ ] Dispute resolution
- [ ] Termination provisions

Subcontractor Performance Tracking

Checklist

- [ ] Preferred - Priority for bidding
- [ ] Approved - Standard bidding
- [ ] Probation - Issues to address
- [ ] Removed - No longer bid

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Pre-Construction Email

```
Subject: Your Project Kickoff - What to Expect

Dear [Client Name],

We're excited to begin work on your [project] starting
[date]! Here's what you need to know:

SCHEDULE
• Start Date: [Date]
• Estimated Completion: [Date]
• Daily Work Hours: [Hours]

WHAT TO EXPECT THIS WEEK
[Specific activities]

COMMUNICATION
• Weekly updates every [day]
• Questions? Contact: [Name] at [phone/email]
• For emergencies: [Number]

PREPARATION
Please ensure:
• [Specific client responsibilities]

We'll take excellent care of your property. If you have
any questions before we start, please don't hesitate
to reach out.

Looking forward to delivering a great result!

[Signature]
```

Weekly Progress Update

```
Subject: [Project Name] - Week [#] Update

Hi [Client Name],

Here's your weekly progress update:
```

```
THIS WEEK'S PROGRESS
✓ [Completed item]
✓ [Completed item]
✓ [Completed item]

NEXT WEEK'S PLAN
• [Planned activity]
• [Planned activity]

SCHEDULE STATUS
We are [on schedule / X days ahead / X days behind].
[If behind, explanation and recovery plan]

BUDGET STATUS
No changes to the agreed scope and price.
[Or: Change order discussion if needed]

PHOTOS
[Attach progress photos]

Questions or concerns? I'm always happy to discuss.

Best,
[Name]
[Phone]
```

Change Order Communication

```
Subject: [Project Name] - Change Order Request

Hi [Client Name],

During our work on [area], we discovered [issue/opportunity].

THE SITUATION
[Clear explanation of what was found]

OPTIONS

Option A: [Description]
• Additional Cost: $[Amount]
• Schedule Impact: [X] days
• Recommendation: [If applicable]

Option B: [Description]
• Additional Cost: $[Amount]
• Schedule Impact: [X] days

Option C: Leave as-is (if applicable)
• Cost: No change
```

```
• Consideration: [What they'd be giving up]

I recommend Option [X] because [reason].

Please let me know how you'd like to proceed. We can
discuss by phone if that's easier - I'm available
[availability].

[Signature]
```

Project Completion Email

```
Subject: Project Complete - Final Walkthrough

Dear [Client Name],

Great news - your [project] is complete!

FINAL WALKTHROUGH
I'd like to schedule a final walkthrough to ensure
everything meets your expectations. Available times:
• [Option 1]
• [Option 2]
• [Option 3]

WHAT TO REVIEW
• [Key areas to inspect]
• Any touch-ups needed
• Questions about care/maintenance

WARRANTY INFORMATION
Your project includes a [X]-year warranty on our
workmanship. Keep this email for reference.

FINAL INVOICE
Please find the final invoice attached. Per our
agreement, payment is due within [X] days.

REVIEWS
If you're happy with our work, we'd appreciate a
review on [Google/Houzz/etc.]. [Link]

Thank you for trusting us with your project!

[Signature]
```

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The Growth Decision Tree

Checklist

- [ ] Hitting target margins on current jobs (>20% gross)
- [ ] Turning away work regularly
- [ ] Core team stable and reliable
- [ ] Systems documented and repeatable
- [ ] Cash reserves for growth investment
- [ ] Clear on what growth looks like

Hiring Your First Employee

Checklist

- [ ] Can't keep up with demand
- [ ] Want to do less field work
- [ ] Need specific skills
- [ ] Ready to scale
- [ ] Ready ☐ Not yet
- [ ] Payroll system
- [ ] Workers' comp insurance

- [ ] Employee handbook
- [ ] Training program
- [ ] Supervision plan

Marketing for Contractors

What actually works:

METHOD	COST	EFFORT	ROI	BEST FOR
Referrals	Free	Low	Highest	All contractors
Google Business	Free	Low	High	Local search
Job site signs	Low	Low	Medium	Brand awareness
Vehicle wraps	Medium	One-time	High	Mobile billboards
Google Ads	Medium	Ongoing	Varies	Specific services
Social media	Low	High	Low	Brand building
Home shows	High	High	Varies	Meeting prospects

The Referral System

Checklist

- [ ] Send handwritten thank-you note
- [ ] Keep referrer updated on outcome
- [ ] Send small gift when referral books ($25-50 value)

1. Estimate Worksheet (Excel)
2. Proposal Template (Word)
3. Job Cost Report (Excel)
4. Daily Report Form (Word/PDF)
5. Weekly Status Report (Excel)
6. Safety Checklists (PDF)
7. Subcontractor Agreement (Word)
8. Client Communication Templates (Word)
9. Overhead Calculator (Excel)

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